

The *tanist* was the heir to the monarchy and immediately took the throne when the king died. He was, essentially, the chief's right-hand man. He was elected for life and considered the most worthy of the same male-line blood of the clan. The deputy prime minister of modern-day Ireland is called the *tanaiste* in Irish.

A modern version of this *tanist* model might be a good one for multigenerational family offices. While members of the Family Council are equal, someone in the second generation needs to fill a leadership role.

We would be reluctant to give him a formal role with a title like "chairman" of the Family Council. Such a perceived inequality could breed contempt. And, obviously, this person in the second generation, and onward, does not occupy the same role that the wealth creator of the first generation does. Instead, the *tanist* would be a protégé of the wealth creator. He would be more focused on family office issues than the other members of the Family Council. Let's face it, not everyone is going to have high levels of interest and understanding of family office matters.

Someone needs to understand all the issues that the family office faces and set the agenda for family meetings. The family office *tanist* needs to help the discussion by introducing important information that might affect Family Council decisions. He needs to make sure that the Family Council discussions stay on track, that they focus on business issues and do not try to deal with personal issues, for example.

The *tanist* should be apprenticed to the current leader. The *tanist* should not receive special treatment or privileges not agreed upon by the Family Council. The Family Council is a collective decision-making body. It shouldn't have a president, but there should be a respectful and capable leader who can help keep things on track. Each generation needs a *tanist*.